legitimate science. *Second*, the scientific world-conception is marked by application of a certain method, namely *logical analysis*." Hence, "logical positivism."

The logical positivists were understandably opposed to philosophical castles in the sky and the tortuous prose they were often defended with. But the logical positivists weren't merely against metaphysics—they believed they could actually dismiss metaphysical claims as meaningless. Meaning, they held, was a matter of *verification:* knowing what a statement means is equivalent to knowing how to verify it using your senses. According to the positivists, when you say "it's hotter outside than it is in here," you really mean "if you go outside, you will feel hotter than you do in here." The statement's meaning is the method of verifying it empirically—and if there's no way of verifying a statement against your senses, then that statement has no meaning. So abstruse statements like Hegel's pronouncements about substance and form, and other metaphysical claims like "there is a God," are meaningless, since they make no contact with the observable world.

But idealist and theological claims aren't the only kinds of statements that make no contact with the senses. There are also more straightforward claims, like "the couch is in the living room even when nobody's there," that can't be confirmed directly. Statements like these, about the existence and persistence of material objects independent of perception, are *realist* claims—they're statements about a real world that exists whether or not there are any humans around. These statements are fundamental to science. Yet some of the positivists, throwing the baby out with the bathwater, dismissed realist claims as meaningless too, because they can't be verified by experience. All that is meaningful, on the positivists' account, are statements about perceptions, along with the purely logical statements of mathematics.

This left positivists in a pickle. They thought it was meaningless to talk about a world that existed independently of perception, but they also wanted to be able to say that science worked. They got around this problem by developing a view of scientific practice that meshed well with their verification theory of meaning. Science, on their account, was about organizing perceptions. Scientific theories were merely methods of predicting future perceptions by churning past perceptions through